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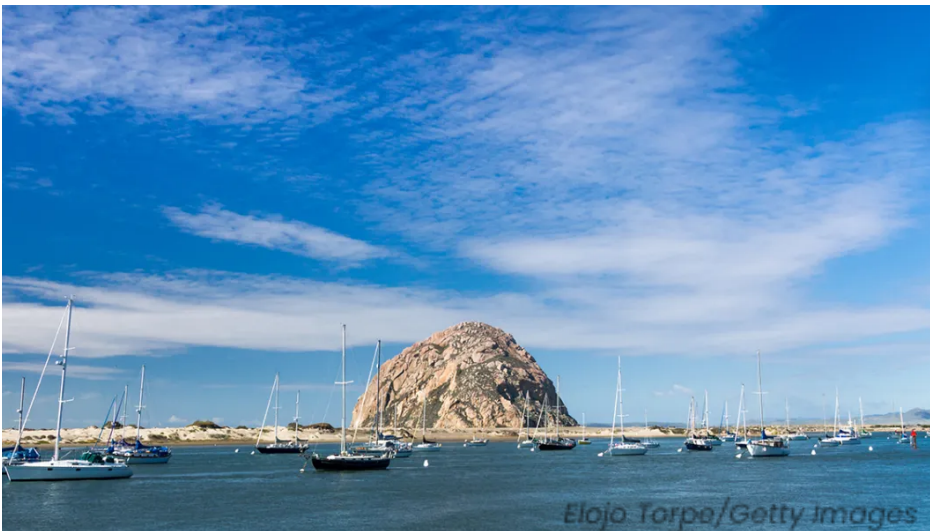
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The quaint coastal town is anchored by a rock but buoyed by fun diversions



Map View

Mapbox © OpenStreetMap

It's impossible to mistake [Morro Bay](#) for any other California seaside town. Just off its shore, a massive, ancient volcanic plug known as Morro Rock rises 576 feet from the ocean, adding a dramatic exclamation point to this haven of natural beauty. Fishermen plied their trade in the shadow of Morro Rock for decades; today, the town in [San Luis Obispo](#) maintains its seafaring charm with a full menu of activities added.

Things to Do in Morro Bay

You can't climb Morro Rock, but you can look for the peregrine falcons that nest there. And it's  just there you'll see birds: So many of them love the Morro Bay area that the Audubon Society has dubbed it one of the country's best places for bird watchers. There's even a [birding festival](#) every Martin Luther King Jr. Day weekend. Nature lives in the water, too, of course—check it out by taking a whale-watching cruise or stopping by the free [Estuary Nature Center](#), a popular hangout for otters

and other sea creatures.

The town is an ambulatory paradise as well: Beaches stretch north and south of town, perfect for

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Embarcadero, a waterfront street with [shops](#) and [restaurants](#). A few blocks inland on Main St. is the [Art Center Morro Bay](#), a gallery where local artists display their work, ranging from paintings and prints to jewelry, sculpture, cards, and more.

Of interest to Half Ironman enthusiasts is the [Ironman 70.3 Morro Bay](#) event that happens annually in May, and consists of a 1.2-mile protected swim in Morro Bay, followed by the 56-mile biking section through rolling hills and vineyards, and finally a 13.1-mile run that finishes along the Embarcadero. Another annual event that draws visitors from far and wide is the World Surf League's [SLO CAL Open at Morro Bay](#) and [Pismo Beach](#), held every December and January, respectively.

Restaurants in Morro Bay

Restaurants in Morro Bay are similarly Instagram-worthy, thanks to a combination of water views and fresh cuisine. Start your day with the crème brûlée French toast at local hangout [Frankie & Lola's](#). Later, watch as the sun begins its slow descent behind Morro Rock while tucking into "naked fish" (simple, with sauces on the side) at [The Galley](#), where dishes incorporate ingredients direct from the head chef's family farm. Visit [Morro Bay Oyster Co.](#) to handpick and shuck your own Pacific Gold oysters; the restaurant contributes to the health of the local ecosystem through its sustainable practices. Or check out the family-owned [Dutchman's Seafood House](#), which has its own dock—so you can count on just-caught seafood.

Where to Stay in Morro Bay

Hotels in Morro Bay also take full advantage of the town's unique geography and geology. Stay in a suite at [Estero Inn](#), where porthole windows create a fitting nautical theme and fireplace rooms have waterfront views. The boutique [Anderson Inn](#) offers coastal allure as well; opt for a view of Morro Rock with a room that offers a fireplace and soaking tub. And the value-focused [Sundown Inn](#) is a Main Street institution; located just a couple blocks from the water, it's been run by the same family for 35 years.

Featured Morro Bay

